

Teaching discussion – Bergen summit
Led by Francis Bond, scribed by Dan
28 July 2026

Emily B: I teach from the Sag/Wasow/Bender textbook; complaints about a 20-year old textbook. Agree that the goal is to show that one can model grammar to provide a mapping from surface strings to semantic representation. To get Slavic examples, maybe assign problem sets in order to collect them. Wambaya has second-position phenomena, so might look at this grammar for ideas about modeling Czech.

Luis: Are you asking "Should I teach HPGS?" or "Should I teach a formal linguistics course?"? For a general linguistics major, they should learn formal syntax.

Francis: No broad agreement among faculty on this need for formal syntax. But if I teach formal syntax, I'll use HPSG.

Stephan: Have received positive feedback from at least one recent student on formal syntax. Stefan Mueller has written a textbook on HPSG Lite for Germanic (300 pages), which might be of interest.

Emily B: Inviting students present to reflect on their syntax course.

Emily L: Hard to jump into syntax without prior knowledge. Also difficult for L2 speakers to cope with grammaticality judgments in English.

Francis: Got positive feedback from Singapore students on ability to model different grammars for differing judgments.

Emily L: On usefulness of the syntax class, students doubt it, and don't see contrast with other syntactic frameworks, especially for computational modeling.

Francis: Need more examples of where using HPSG for NLP would be useful.

Emily B: No, expect students to be better scientists of language when they see that utterances are not just bags of words.

Luis: Need knowledge of language structure in order to do systematic error analysis of existing NLP tool output. Also needed to construct variants of data sets, aware of alternation patterns. Hard to do without syntax.

Francis: To keep course content manageable, don't cover many core phenomena such as relative clauses.

Spencer: Encountered other syntactic phenomena in other courses at UW even though not covered in Emily's course. Having the backbone of HPSG from that course, had a way to organize thinking about these other phenomena.

Emily B: Aiming to teach methodology and the approach to observed linguistic phenomena.

Spencer: One main purpose of formal syntax is to learn how to formulate and evaluate hypotheses about linguistic phenomena. Many fellow students have appreciated the rigor and clarity provided by the framework and formalism.

Emily B: At some points in the quarter, stop to interrogate students about what they are finding useful or surprising so far. Noted that I teach grad students, not the undergrads you're teaching. Use demo tools and maybe even usage assignments to engage students in implementations and what they can reveal about the language.

Isaac: Remembers complaints about the level of precision demanded in producing an analysis in the HPSG framework. Some students value that clarity and see the effort as well rewarded. Many come in with the expectation that the UW program will prepare them for a language technology job, with focus on practical skills.

Emily L: Maybe different approach needed for teaching undergrads. Maybe check the UTexas resources for teaching.

Ann: Note resources used at Charles University, including some venerable ones. Maybe worth checking with colleagues there. Also, don't worry about your students not doing the reading: this seems to be a widespread trend among students.

Petter: I teach only limited syntax, about 6 hours/semester per course.

Spencer: On balance between providing scaffolding and letting students wrestle with concepts, it's probably an inherent tension; I enjoyed the wrestling, but not all share that view, so more scaffolding could help. Strongly support your adding more support in class for students new to the subject matter.

John: Did teach some syntax at the beginning of language course for computer science students, and found the overseas ones had better mastery of core concepts, different from the monolingual students.

Ann: Even simple notions such as part of speech proved to be useful.

Luis: Students differ from country to country; Singapore students rose to challenges in class, while Dutch students exhibit less motivation, and maybe also Czech ones, not working as hard for a high grade; passing is enough.

Stephan: Liked the ACL paper just blitzed on comparing human vs. LLM texts, so maybe this arena could provide a teaching testbed, looking at differences in diversity of lexicon and constructions. Maybe provide the pipeline to let students apply our tools to texts and study their properties.

Emily B: Did we help you, Francis?

Francis: Yes. Thanks to the students present, and to the rest. Will add more Slavic examples, and look at adding more scaffolding.

Emily B: Students who worked on building grammars found interest from employers on that skill set and experience.